(first published 1884–98; Atlantic Publishers and Distributors, 1990). Pir Muhammad was escaping Burhanpur, which he had recently sacked with his usual brutality. ‘That city also he took by storm,’ writes Nizamuddin, ‘and gave orders for a general massacre. Many of the learned men and saiyids of the place he caused to be decapitated in his presence.’ This time, however, an alliance of local rulers – joined, as luck would have it, by Baz Bahadur – retaliated, forcing Pir Muhammad to flee. As he was wading across the Narmada with his commanders, they passed by a caravan of camels, one of whom ‘came up and bit the horse upon which he was riding. He was thrown off into the water and drowned, thus receiving the recompense of his deeds.’ See Nizamuddin Ahmad, ‘Tabakat-i Akbari’, in *The History of India, As Told by Its Own Historians*, trans. H.M. Elliot, vol. 5 (Trübner and Co., 1873).

. Abu’l Fazl, *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl* (completed by Inayatullah), vol. 1, trans. Henry Beveridge (First published 1902–1939; Low Price Publications, 2017).

. Michael H. Fisher, *A Short History of the Mughal Empire* (I.B. Tauris, 2016).

. Akbar wasn’t just asking for a one-time tribute and deference from these men, he was trying to ensure a steady supply of funds to his treasury. Thus, Shamsuddin Ataka’s appointment as vakil was accompanied by a cabinet reshuffle of sorts, in which Itimad Khan, an accountant previously employed by Sher Shah Suri, began to work with Akbar’s ataka on ‘realising the state’s share [of revenue from the fiefs] that had long been in default’. The nobility was not pleased, particularly not Maham’s faction. This may well be one of the reasons why Adham murdered Shamsuddin. See Iqtidar Alam Khan, *The Political Biography of a Mughal Noble: Mun’im Khan Khan-i Khanan, 1497–1575* (Orient Longman, 1973).

.Stephen F. Dale, *The Muslim Empires of the Ottomans, Safavids, and Mughals* (Cambridge University Press, 2010).

. Ali Anooshahr, ‘Mughals, Mongols, and Mongrels: The Challenge of Aristocracy and the Rise of the Mughal State in the *Tarikh-i Rashidi*’, *Journal of Early Modern History*, vol. 18, 2014.

. Babur, writes Michael H. Fisher, ‘regarded most of his contemporary Mongols as uncultured and fierce but unreliable warriors, with a strong penchant for predatory looting of foe and friend’.

Humayun, meanwhile, seems to have held the aristocratic ‘Moghul’ in some contempt. Having returned to Hindustan, he rewarded the faithful Jouher with a fief, and sent him off with this cautionary tale, saying, ‘Young man, listen to this story as a piece of advice.’ A Moghul having received an appointment, began his supposed duty by snatching a blanket from the shoulders of a citizen. Upon the man’s remonstrating, he said, ‘You scoundrel, don’t you know that I have been sent by Government to collect?’ Jouher’s translator notes that ‘The Moghuls are made the butts of numerous anecdotes.’ See Jouher, *The Tezkereh al Vakiat, or Private Memoirs of Moghul Emperor Humayun by Jouher*, trans. Major Charles Stewart (Oriental Translation Fund, 1832).

. Khan, *The Political Biography of a Mughal Noble.*

. *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 2.

. Nizamuddin Ahmad, *Tabakat-i Akbari*.

.*The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 2.

. In a painting of the scene, Akbar seems to have caught the arrow mid-flight, there is no hint of a wound on his clean, white clothes, while the sniper lies dead in the foreground, drenched in blood.

. *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 2.

.Abu’l Fazl, *The History of Akbar*, vol. 3, trans. W.M. Thackston (Murty Classical Library of India, Harvard University Press, 2017).

. *The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 2.

. Afzal Husain, *The Nobility under Akbar and Jahangir: A Study of Family Groups* (Manohar Publishers, 1999).

.*The Akbarnama of Abu’l Fazl*, vol. 2.